

BUILD YOUR AI CEO — THE COMPLETE SETUP GUIDE

OpenClaw Configuration Template

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MODULE 4 — DOWNLOAD PACKET

Your openclaw.json Starter File

What Is the Config File?

The `openclaw.json` file is OpenClaw's master configuration. It tells the system where your workspace lives, which AI model to use, how to connect to Discord, and what your agent's identity is.

Think of it as the settings panel for your entire AI CEO system — everything that makes your instance uniquely yours is defined here.

Command Quotes — Important Quick Tip Before Running Terminal Commands

When you see quotes in the commands shown throughout this guide, they must be **straight quotes**.

Pages (and most word processors) automatically convert your quotes to **curly quotes** as you type. If you copy and paste curly quotes into the Terminal, the command will fail and you'll get errors. This is one of the most common reasons people get stuck.

✅ **Straight quotes — always use these in Terminal:**

`"` double `'` single

❌ **Curly quotes — these will break your commands:**

“ ” double ‘ ’ single

Always use straight quotes when typing or pasting commands into Terminal. If you're copying from Pages or a document, double-check and fix any curly quotes to straight ones before running the command.

This small detail will save you a ton of frustration.

Where Does It Live?

By default, OpenClaw looks for the config file at:

```
~/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

This is a hidden folder in your home directory. If it doesn't exist yet, you'll create it as part of this setup.

To navigate there in Terminal:

```
▷  TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL
```

```
cd ~/.openclaw
```

To check if the file already exists:

```
▷  TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL
```

```
ls -la ~/.openclaw/
```

The Complete Starter Template

Copy everything below and paste it into your `openclaw.json` file. Then replace every `[PLACEHOLDER]` value with your real information. Instructions for each field follow the template.

```
{
  "workspace": "/Users/[YOUR_MAC_USERNAME]/[PATH_TO_YOUR_WORKSPACE]",

  "model": "anthropic/claude-sonnet-4-6",

  "agent": {
    "name": "[YOUR_AI_NAME]",
    "identity": "[YOUR_AI_NAME] is your AI Chief Executive. It operates from your workspace, manages
  },

  "discord": {
    "token": "[YOUR_DISCORD_BOT_TOKEN]",
    "guildId": "[YOUR_DISCORD_SERVER_ID]",
    "channels": {
      "operator": "[OPERATOR_CHANNEL_ID]",
      "morning-brief": "[MORNING_BRIEF_CHANNEL_ID]",
      "bugs": "[BUGS_CHANNEL_ID]",
      "content": "[CONTENT_CHANNEL_ID]",
      "strategy": "[STRATEGY_CHANNEL_ID]",
      "nightly-review": "[NIGHTLY_REVIEW_CHANNEL_ID]"
    }
  }
}
```

Field-by-Field Instructions

workspace

Your local workspace path — the root directory where all your identity files, ventures, and agent resources live.

How to find your Mac username:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
whoami
```

This prints your username (e.g., `Cyrus`).

Example value:

```
"workspace": "/Users/cyrus/workspace"
```

Replace `cyrus` with your actual Mac username and adjust the folder path if your workspace is in a different location.

`model`

The AI model your system uses by default. We recommend starting with:

```
"model": "anthropic/claude-sonnet-4-6"
```

This is Claude Sonnet — fast, capable, and cost-efficient. Do not change this unless you have a specific reason to.

`agent.name`

The name of your AI CEO. This is the name it uses in conversations and logs.

Example:

```
"name": "Cyrus"
```

Use whatever name you chose for your AI in SOUL.md and IDENTITY.md.

`agent.identity`

A one or two sentence description of your AI's role. This gives OpenClaw context about what your agent is for.

Example:

```
"identity": "Cyrus is my AI Chief Executive. It manages my ventures, coordinates agents, and keeps m
```

Keep this short — your detailed identity configuration is in your SOUL.md and IDENTITY.md files.

`discord.token`

Your Discord bot's private token. You get this from the Discord Developer Portal when you create your bot.

⚠️ This is sensitive — treat it like an API key. Never share it or commit it to a public repository.

Example:

```
"token": "MTI4NDM0NjI4MjQ2NzYwNzY2Ng.GxxxxX.xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx"
```

See the **Discord Setup Checklist** (discord-setup-checklist.md) for instructions on generating your bot token.

`discord.guildId`

Your Discord server's unique ID. "Guild" is Discord's technical name for a server.

How to find your Server ID:

1. Open Discord
2. Go to User Settings → Advanced → Enable **Developer Mode**
3. Right-click your server name in the left sidebar
4. Click "**Copy Server ID**"

Example:

```
"guildId": "1234567890123456789"
```

`discord.channels`

The IDs of each Discord channel your AI uses. Each channel has a specific purpose:

Channel Key	Channel Purpose
<code>operator</code>	Your main control channel — where you chat with your AI
<code>morning-brief</code>	Where your AI posts its daily morning briefing
<code>bugs</code>	Where error reports and system issues are logged
<code>content</code>	Content ideas, drafts, and publishing coordination
<code>strategy</code>	Strategic discussions, venture proposals, research
<code>nightly-review</code>	Nightly summaries and memory extraction reports

How to find Channel IDs:

1. In Discord with Developer Mode enabled
2. Right-click any channel name
3. Click "**Copy Channel ID**"

Example:

```
"channels": {  
  "operator":      "1234567890123456001",  
  "morning-brief": "1234567890123456002",  
  "bugs":          "1234567890123456003",  
  "content":       "1234567890123456004",  
  "strategy":      "1234567890123456005",  
  "nightly-review": "1234567890123456006"  
}
```

Step-by-Step: Creating Your Config File

Step 1 — Create the .openclaw directory (if it doesn't exist)

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
mkdir -p ~/.openclaw
```

Step 2 — Create and open the config file

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
nano ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

Step 3 — Paste the template

Copy the starter template from above and paste it into the editor.

Step 4 — Fill in your values

Replace every `[PLACEHOLDER]` with your real information using the field instructions above.

Step 5 — Save the file

- Press `Control + X`

- Press `Y` to confirm saving
- Press `Enter`

Step 6 — Verify the file looks correct

▷ `TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL`

```
cat ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

This will print your config. Review it and confirm there are no obvious typos or missing values.

How to Restart OpenClaw After Changes

Any time you modify your config file, restart OpenClaw for the changes to take effect:

▷ `TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL`

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

You should see a confirmation message indicating the gateway restarted successfully.

To check that OpenClaw is running:

▷ `TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL`

```
openclaw gateway status
```

Common Config Errors and Fixes

Error: "Invalid JSON" or "Unexpected token"

Your JSON has a syntax error — likely a missing comma, quote, or bracket.

Fix: Run this command to check your JSON for errors:

▷ `TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL`

```
cat ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json | python3 -m json.tool
```

This will point to the exact line with the problem. Common issues:

- Missing comma after a field
 - Extra comma after the last field in an object
 - Unmatched quotes or brackets
-

Error: "Bot token invalid" or "Discord authentication failed"

Your bot token is wrong or has been revoked.

Fix:

1. Go to discord.com/developers/applications
 2. Select your bot application
 3. Go to the **Bot** tab
 4. Click "**Reset Token**" to generate a fresh token
 5. Copy the new token and update your config
-

Error: "Channel not found" or "Unknown channel"

The channel ID you entered doesn't exist or the bot doesn't have access to it.

Fix:

1. Confirm the channel ID by right-clicking the channel in Discord → Copy Channel ID
 2. Make sure your bot has been invited to the server with the correct permissions
 3. Confirm the bot has access to that specific channel
-

Error: "Workspace path does not exist"

The path you entered for `workspace` doesn't exist on your machine.

Fix:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
ls /Users/[your-username]/[your-workspace-folder]
```

If this returns an error, the path is wrong or the folder doesn't exist. Create it:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND – COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
mkdir -p /Users/[your-username]/workspace
```

OpenClaw starts but AI isn't responding

Check that your API keys are loaded in your environment:

▷ **TERMINAL COMMAND — COPY & PASTE INTO TERMINAL**

```
echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY
```

If blank, re-run `source ~/.zshrc` and restart OpenClaw.

Final Checklist

- ☐ `~/.openclaw/openclaw.json` file created
- ☐ `workspace` path is correct and the folder exists
- ☐ `model` is set to `anthropic/claude-sonnet-4-6`
- ☐ `agent.name` matches your AI's name in SOUL.md/IDENTITY.md
- ☐ Discord bot token entered (from Discord Developer Portal)
- ☐ Discord server ID entered
- ☐ All 6 channel IDs entered
- ☐ JSON is valid (no syntax errors)
- ☐ `openclaw gateway restart` run successfully
- ☐ `openclaw gateway status` shows running

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